

PART 3/PART 3B: FACTION OUTPOSTS

[by Justin Alexander – January 24th, 2019](#)



As you may have already ascertained, this remix is simply tossing out most of *Chapter 4: Dragon Season* from the original campaign. The original sequences no longer work with the more dynamic, multi-faction approach we're using for the remix, and I'm simply not that interested in these sorts of pre-scripted, linear, and often railroaded sequences.

We're still going to take advantage of some of the raw material in *Chapter 4*, however, to create a number of Outposts for each faction. (In some ways you can think of this as sort of taking the best version of each location from the campaign.)

BREGAN D'AERTHE OUTPOSTS

FENERUS STORMCASTLE'S HOUSE (Trade Ward, Quill Alley – *Dragon Heist*, p. 63): Fenerus Stormcastle was the founder of the Blood Hawk Posse, a gang of horse-riding brigands that, to this day, harries travelers on the road to Amphail. When he was drummed out of the gang after a botched raid, Fenerus "retired" to Waterdeep and joined the Guild of Chandlers and Lamplighters. He supplements his income by spying for the city of Luskan and providing his contacts with information on the political climate in Waterdeep, as well as juicy bits of news overheard on his nightly rounds through the Trades Ward.

Since the Sea Maidens Faire arrived in Waterdeep, Fenerus has also been acting as a message drop for Bregan D'Aerthe. Fenerus collects messages from various covert drops and brings them back to his house, where they are collected by Krebbyg Masq'il'yr and taken back to Jarlaxle's ship.

Questioning Fenerus: Although he's supposed to be a cut-out, Fenerus once followed Krebbyg after Jarlaxle's lieutenant picked up the messages and knows that they're being taken to the Sea Maidens Faire.

Following Krebbyg: Krebbyg comes to collect messages from Fenerus once every 1d3 days. If the PCs stake out the house long enough, they may also be able to follow him to the Sea Maidens Faire.

Messages: The PCs may be able to capture several messages. These are written in code, requiring an Intelligence test (DC 16) to decipher. (The check is made with advantage if they speak Drow.) The contents of these messages will vary depending on when, exactly, the PCs come to Fenerus' house. Possibilities include:

- Information unrelated to the Grand Game, most likely revolving around attempting to identify Masked Lords, gain blackmail material over them, and/or diplomatic assessments of their support for Luskan joining the Lords' Alliance.
- A report from the Gralhund Villa observation team: "Watchpost established in the manor south of the Gralhund Villa. We have identified members of the Black Network onsite. We have also observed gazers in the area, although we have not yet determined which beholders' dark dreams they've sprung out of. – Fel'Rekt Lafeen"
- "Westra Moltimmur is demanding three additional dresses for Sapphiria's Booty. Considerable expense. Rongquan Mystere may need to put in an appearance." (A little research can quickly identify these names as referring to the Seven Masks Theater, see below.)
- "The Council of Musicians, Instrument-Makers, & Choristers refuses to withdraw their objection to the Sea Maidens Faire as a public entertainment. But I've resolved the matter by getting license from the Jesters' Guild. We only need to make payment to them with claim that we are employing a guild entertainer, even though we're not. The guilds in this city are even more rotten than those in Luskan."
- "Nimblewright delivery completed to Bowgentra Summerteaen. We have eyes up in the Watchful Order." (Summerteaen is the leader of the Watchful Order of Magists and Protectors, a guild for wizards and sorcerers in Waterdeep.)

SEVEN MASKS THEATER (*Dragon Heist*, p. 75): Use the description of the Autumn version of the theater from the original campaign. Jarlaxle owns this theater under the false identity of Rongquan Mystere. One of the dressing rooms is kept empty as a safe house for D'Aerthe agents in trouble. Jarlaxle will also use the theater as a "neutral" meeting place with other factions (including the PCs).

Malcolm Brizzenbright: We'll also transplant Brizzenbright's Ghost from the Winter version of the Theater (see *Dragon Heist*, p. 76). He's the founder of the Seven Masks Theater, but has been dead for over thirty years.

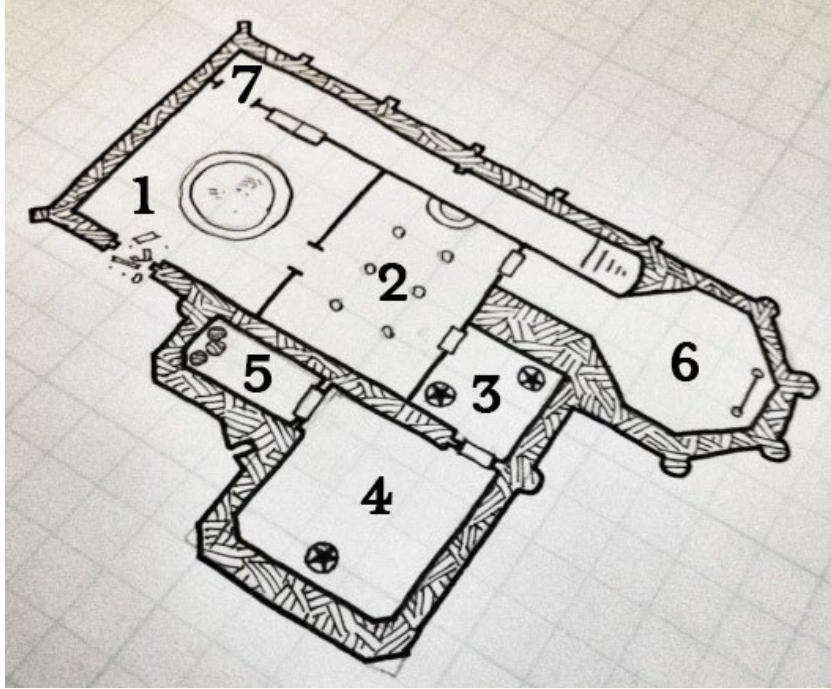
- He knows that "Rongquan Mystere" is a fake identity, and he's anxious that his theater not be used for nefarious purposes.
- He can identify the dressing room being used as a safe house.
- He once saw "Rongquan" speaking with drow in the lobby during a performance of *The Mad Mage's Seven Riddles*. They mentioned something called the "Sea Maidens Faire".

Area P6 – Stage Manager's Office: Amongst the other papers dealing with theater work is a *Letter Regarding Fenerus Stormcastle's House*. Directed simply to "J", it warns him that, "There have been strange eyes fixed upon the house of Fenerus Stormcastle and flights of black snakes have been seen flocking the skies of the Trades Ward. Greater care should be taken when messengers approach the house, and we may want to find an alternative asset. I leave it to your judgment whether or not Fenerus himself should be warned. - K"

- *GM Note:* "J" is Jarlaxle Baenre and "K" is Krebbyg.

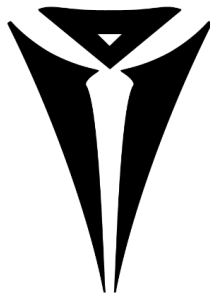
CASSALANTER OUTPOSTS

ASMODEAN SHRINE (North Ward, Aveen Street): From the outside, this appears to be a nondescript residence. The entire interior of the house, however, has been converted into a shrine dedicated to Asmodeus. The Cassalanter discovered the ancient Hell cyst (see Area 8) below the house, bought the property, and installed members of the cult.



Area 1 – Summoning Circle: Demonic sigils have been painted onto the floor to form a summoning circle. Tapping into the power of the Hell cyst, the circle can be used to summon 2 **imps** once every nine days.

Area 2 – Styxian Shrine: Intertwined figures of demons and devils twist about the columns in this room, a visceral depiction of the savage brutality of the Blood War. At one end of the room there is a small font of reddish-gray stone that extrudes from the wall. The cistern is half-filled with grayish water, enchanted to act as the water of the River Styx. Those drinking from it must succeed at a DC 14 Wisdom saving throw or lose all of their memories for 8 hours. (The cultists consider this a test of their faith and a sacrament.) On the wall above the font, the symbol of Asmodeus has been painted on the wall in blood.



Area 3 – Demonic Statues: Two large demonic statues – one depicting a kyton (chain devil) and the other a bezekira (hellcat) – face off against each other.

Area 4 – Chapter House: Huge, writhing tentacles seem to erupt from an arcane circle on the far side of this room, but it's just a disturbingly lifelike statue given the semblance of life by an *animate object* spell (50 hp, AC 10, +6 to hit, 2d20+2 damage, Str 14, Dex 10). The tentacles are fastened to the floor and only attack a target within 10 feet if given a command by one of the cultists; otherwise they just writhe artistically.

Two cots are lined up against the wall. A long trestle table runs down the middle of the room with benches to either side.

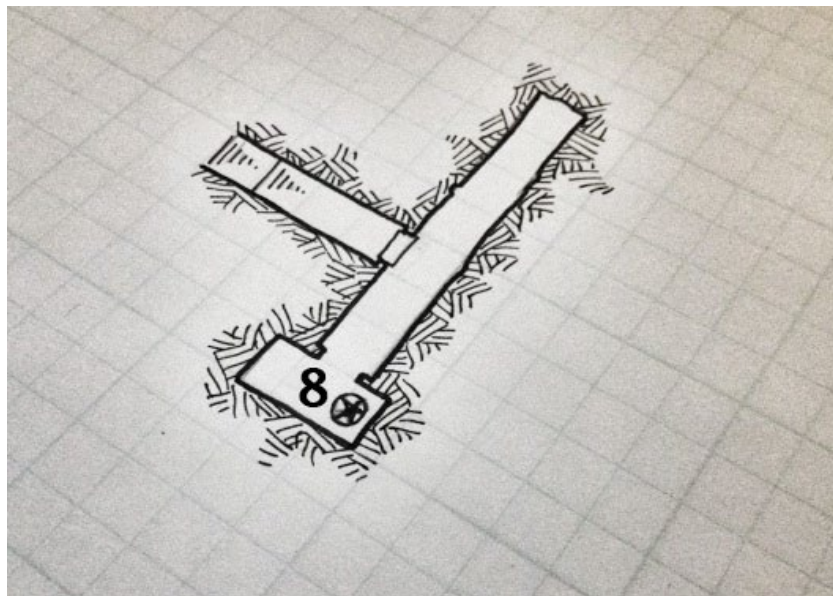
Under the cot is *Arn's Book of Worship*: This text with a stylized goat's head drawn in blood upon its plain brown cover, contains a number of "high prayers" to Asmodeus and the description of a number of banal demonic rites of worship. On the inside back cover, in simple handwriting, one can read, "This book belongs to Arn Xalrondar, of the Windmill upon Coachlamp Lane.")

Area 5 – Demonic Jelly: Three large wooden kegs. A mysterious amber jelly within them acts like a *potion of hill giant strength* if rubbed over the body (6 doses per keg).

Area 6 – Mirror of the Fiend: A large mirror with an obsidian frame carved with demonic sigils stands at the far end of this chamber. Anyone seeing themselves reflected in the mirror is bathed in purplish flames which deal 1d6 damage per round to most creatures, but heal 1d6 damage per round for fiends.

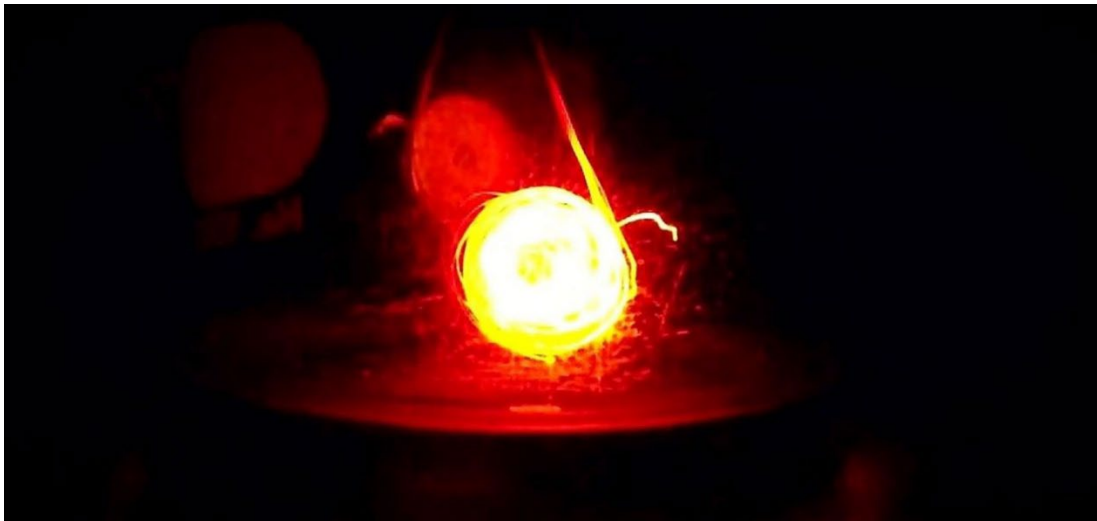
- **Noble Sigil:** On the back of the mirror is carved a small rune. A DC 13 Intelligence (History) check reveals that this is a Waterdhavian noble sigil; a practice that was once common in Waterdeep, but which died out over a century ago. A DC 16 check identifies this specific rune as indicating that the mirror belonged to the Cassalanter family.

Area 7 – Passage of the Nine Hells: The plaster walls of this long hallway are completely covered in a mural seamlessly depicting the Nine Hells – the desolate wasteland of Avernus; the malefic green skies of Dis; the endless rotting bogs of Minauros; the magma-ridden valleys of Phlegethos; the frozen sea of Stygia; the cyclopean basalt of Malbolge; the endless, maze-like ruins of Maladomini; the serrated glaciers of Cania. At the far end, above the arch leading to the descending stairs, is depicted the Malsheem, the Citadel of Hell, in Nessus, the Ninth Circle of Hell.



Area 8 – The Hell Cyst: The entire lower level of the shrine is clearly much, much older than the house above it. The walls were once covered in bas relief, but the stone has worn away and the carvings have become unrecognizable.

In a niche one end of the cramped corridor, the extrusions of stone seem to reach out from the wall and almost cradle a glowing ball of hellish red light which floats in midair.



Those who dare to lean close to the ball will discover that – at a distance of a few inches or so – they can actually peer into it (or perhaps, more accurately, *through* it). Doing so is like peering through a heavily distorted lens into a volcanic hell. (The Hell cyst is actually a pin-prick of Hell co-located onto the Material Plane. There is no way to traverse or communicate through the event horizon of the cyst, but the cyst is nevertheless a literal manifestation of Hell on Earth and can be used as the focus for a number of demonic rites.)

ASMODEAN SHRINE - ROSTER

1 cult fanatic + 2 imps	Area 1	MM p. 345, MM p. 76
1 apprentice wizard + 2 imps	Area 2	DH p. 194, MM p. 76
2 cult fanatics	Area 4	MM p. 345

Questioning Cultists: Successfully questioning the cultists will reveal that rituals are held at a site beneath the Cassalanter Villa. The fanatics will report that their contact there is Willifort Crowell (which might lead the PCs to believe that the Cassalanter are unaware of what's happening in their own home); the wizard knows better and may be made to reveal as much.

Instructions from Lord Cassalanter: The apprentice wizard carries a note from Lord Cassalanter instructing that the next pair of imps to emerge from the summoning circle should be dispatched to perform surveillance on the Sea Maidens Faire, which he believes to have become of particular importance as a result of recent intelligence which has come into his possession. (The note might mention the PCs by name here if they were the source of this intelligence; otherwise he names Willifort Crowelle.) "The imps should report back to me directly at the villa."

CONVERTED WINDMILL (Southern Ward, Coachlamp Lane): Use the description of the Summer version of the Converted Windmill (see *Dragon Heist*, p. 88). It's used as an apartment by Arn Xalrondar (LE male Tethyrian human) and Seffia Naelryke (LE female Tethyrian human), both **cult fanatics**.

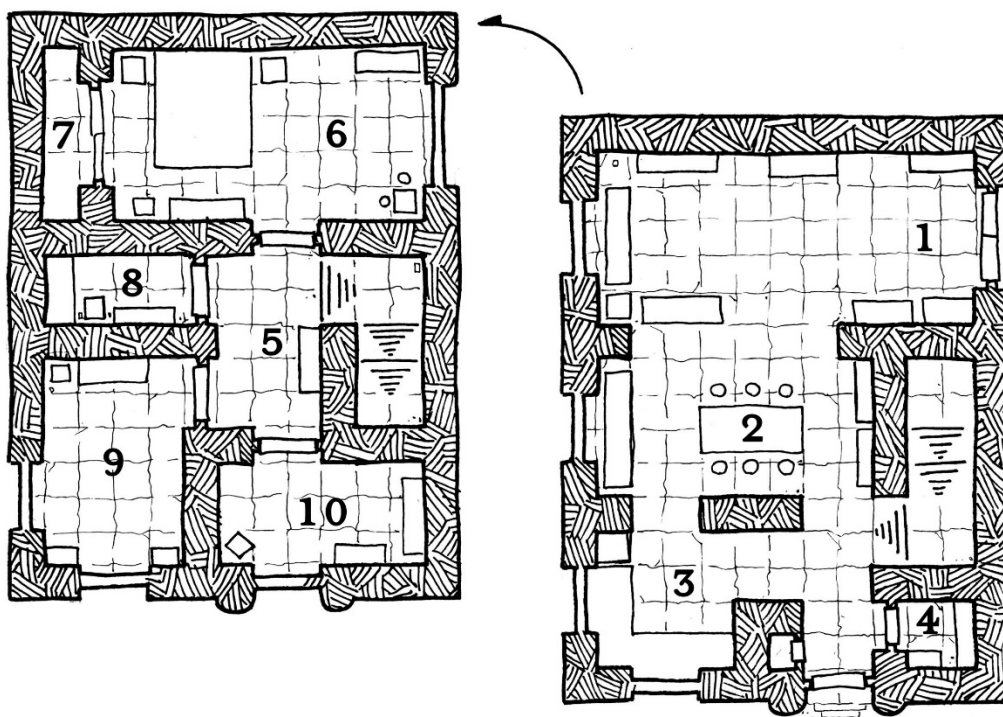
Area W7 – Secure Apartment:

- A note can be found under the bed. It reads: "Meeting Ches 17th, the shrine on Aveen Street".

Area W8 – The Room of Rituals: A pentagram has been painted on the floor in blood. At the points of the pentagram are five black globs of wax — the remains of burned candles — and there's a variety of writing in charcoal surrounding the pentagram. There is a desk along one wall, covered in a mass of papers.

- **The Ritual – DC 15 Intelligence (Arcana):** The ritual performed here was a form of weak demonic divination, similar to a *legend lore* or *contact other plane* spell, but more like a weakly amped up Ouija board or similar parlor trick. The runes indicate that this ritual was performed in an effort to find something associated with "Neverember", "the wealth of Waterdeep", "Golorr", and "that which has been lost to the waters of Lethe" (although the latter appears to be more of a symbolic representation rather than a literal one).
- **Desk:** At the center of the drift of miscellaneous papers is a map of Waterdeep. Strange lines of blood criss-cross the map in bizarre patterns, but one location within the City of the Dead has been picked out from the pattern and circled in black charcoal. Accompanying writing identifies this as the "Brandath Crypt".
- *GM Note:* This ritual, performed by Seffia, identified the Brandath Crypt as the hiding place of one of the Eyes. It actually only worked, however, because the Vault is actually hidden below the Crypt (making it a much more powerful locus for the conceptual anchors of the ritual), although Seffia didn't realize that.

XANATHARIAN OUTPOSTS



TERASSE ESTATE (Castle Ward, Elsambul's Lane): The Terasse Estate is a modest rowhouse residence in the Castle Ward which is secretly owned by Xanathar. It is occupied by a Xanatharian operative named Keln Trigos, a tiefling **priest** (MM p. 348). Keln sometimes provides healing services to injured Xanatharians, but the house is more notable because it's a designated gladiatorial gathering point: Those who wish to attend the gladiatorial combats in Xanathar's Lair must go to one of these gathering points (there are several throughout the city, some heading through the sewers to X1, others following the route described below) in order to be escorted, as a group, to the games (and back).

Area 1 – Front Door: Those coming to the Terasse Estate must give a specific knock and an accompanying pass-phrase to be given entrance. There are two different combinations, one for healing services ("I heard the red hand was hot") and another for the gladiatorial gatherings ("the bawdy star shines bright tonight").

Area 2 – Dining Room: Those here for gladiatorial gatherings are brought together in this room for light socializing and the enjoyment of various delicacies placed upon the table. (Roasted bulette with rare Shou Louan spices. [Rothé](#) carpaccio with vargouille head cheese.)

Area 3 – Kitchen: A large rug of reddish scales covers the floor here. This can be thrown back to reveal a trap door with a narrow staircase leading down to an underground dock. Those heading to the gladiatorial gatherings will be blindfolded before being led down the stairs, and the blindfolds will remain in place until the boat arrive at another secret dock in the caverns near Skullport. This dock connects to a passage which intersects the one leading from Area X4 of Xanathar's Lair to the Guts & Garter in Skullport.



Area 4 – Storeroom: Trigos's larder and healing supplies.

Area 5 – Upper Landing: An ancient tapestry on the wall depicts a heavily stylized beholder with several humanoid figures of various races bowing in obeisance before it.

- **Injury Reports:** A logbook hanging on the wall here records those who have been treated here. The names listed are clear pseudonyms designed to keep the patrons of this house of healing anonymous. One recent entry, however, notes, that a particular wound from an arrow was the result of "incautious observation of the windmill on Coachlamp Lane". (GM Note: This refers to the Converted Windmill, a Cassalanter outpost.)

Area 6-7 – Master Suite: This is Trigos's bedchamber, with walk-in closet.

- **Desk:** Trigos has a variety of expensive stationeries and writing utensils for performing his correspondence, but he also has a burn-pot that he obviously uses to destroy that correspondence on a regular basis. One recent bit of correspondence he hasn't had a chance to reply to yet, however, is *Instructions for Gladiatorial Weaponry*: "The shipment of special weapons that X requested will be sent by Grinda Garloth in Mistshore. See that they're bundled up and sent along with the next audience procession. -Ahmaergo" (GM Note: If it becomes notable, this is simply a bunch of vicious-looking oddities – many of them foreign weapons from distant lands – destined for the gladiatorial combats.)

Areas 8-10 – Sick Rooms: These bedrooms are used by Xanatharian agents who come to Trigos for his healing arts.

- **An Ill Man's Note:** On the bedside table of a Xanatharian agent there's a note which reads: "Orb Confectioners. / Eight small eyes. / How would you like those arranged? / Around an ocular cake."

GRINDA GARLOTH: Just use the base description of Mistshore (see *Dragon Heist*, p. 65), ignoring all of the seasonal variants. Grinda is allied with Xanathar, working primarily as a black market armorer: Xanatharian agents can come to Grinda and get outfitted with high quality equipment. Grinda also freelances, renting her equipment (and Xanathar's equipment) to third parties.

Area D2: Grinda's chest contains:

- 500 gp
- *A Note Regarding Gladiatorial Weaponry*: "Xanathar wants the full bundle of weaponry delivered to Terasse's house of healing on Elsambul's Lane no later than two days from now so that it can be sent down to headquarters with the next gladiatorial audience. Don't be late! He's looking forward to seeing some exotic gutting. -Ahmaergo" (GM Note: If it becomes notable, this is simple a bunch of vicious-looking oddities — many of them foreign weapons from distant lands — destined for the gladiatorial combats.)

Area D3: Grinda has a wide assortment of mundane arms and armor (including several single-shot pistols). At any given time, she also has 1d4 pieces of magic arms and armor (roll on Table F, DMG p. 146), and 1d4 miscellaneous magic items (roll on Table A or B, DMG p. 145)

XANATHAR SEWER HIDEOUT, TAKE 2: The Xanathar Guild maintains a number of sewer hideouts throughout Waterdeep. This one is a duergar operation run by Korgstrod Uxgulm. Use the Autumn version of the Cellar Complex (see *Dragon Heist*, p. 86).

Orb Confectioners (Southern Ward, : The sewer hideout can be accessed from the cellar (Area B1) of the Orb Confectioners, a shop specializing in sweets fashion like eyes (smallcakes, sweatmeats, sugar plates, candied nuts).

- **Passphrase:** Those asking for "eight small eyes" are asked, "How would you like those arranged?" They are to answer, "Around an ocular cake." If they do so, they are escorted to the basement stairs.



Area B7 – *Mechanical Beholder*: Mixed in with the other material in this room is a letter.

- *On the Delivery of a Mechanical Beholder*: "X is outraged that you bungling incompetents couldn't get his *piece de triumphe* working for the Shipwrights' Ball! If it isn't seen swooping over the Feasts of Leirun, he'll have your guts for garters! See that it's delivered to Terasse's house of healing on Elsambul's Lane by the ninth of Tarsakh or be prepared to pay for it with your heads! - Ahmaergo"

Area B8: Remove the stairs up.

Area B9b – Korgstrud’s Room: The chest at the foot of his bed is a **mimic**. The coffer in a secret compartment under the bed (DC 13 to find) contains 500 gp and *Correspondence with N’arl Xibrindas*.

- *Correspondence with N’arl Xibrindas:* “Korgstroed – It is very important that this be kept in strictest confidence. Only you, me, and X know of the smokepowder. It must be brought to the Staircase of Eyes on the night of the 1st at precisely the stroke of eleven. Use disposable muscle. I will mark the sewer tunnels west of your hideout with a red eye to guide your men. – N’arl Xibrindas.”
- *GM Note:* N’arl’s guildsign leads to Area X1 of Xanathar’s Lair (the secret entrance). See *Part 5B: Finding Floon* for guidelines on following guildsign. Due to its age, this guildsign requires DC 15 checks to follow and the final check is DC 17 because N’arl deliberately tried to destroy the symbols nearest Xanathar’s lair. If the PCs fail three times before succeeding, it indicates that time and/or N’arl have done too much damage and they’ve lost the trail.

ZHENTARIM OUTPOSTS

ZHENTARIM INTERROGATION HOUSE (Trade Ward, Brindul Alley): Avareen Windrivver (LE female Illuskan human **spy**) and Zorbog Jyarkoth (NE male Turami human **thug**) maintain this combination safe house / covert interrogation center.

- Use the Map for house L1 on p. 62 of *Dragon Heist*.

Front Room: Avareen and Zorbog live here. A nest of three black **flying snakes** (used by the Zhents for sending messages) nest in a corner near the ceiling.

- Avareen carries a pass-amulet for Kolat Tower (see Part 4).
- As the PCs are exploring the house, a **flying snake** arrives with *A Directive to Zorbog*. Signed by “Manshoon”, it exhorts Zorbog to “gather the usual gang” and kidnap “Fenerus Stormcastle, who lives on Quill Alley”, a “known associate of these new meddlers in the Grand Game”. Zorbog is to squeeze Fenerus until he reveals everything he knows about these new participants.

Backroom: The backroom has a rack and several other instruments of torture, along with an arcane circle painted on the floor in the corner. Currently strapped into the rack is Ott Steeltoes, a shield dwarf wearing a leather skullcap stitched with fake beholder eyestalks. Ott is a Xanatharian agent captured by the Zhentarim.

Rescuing Ott:

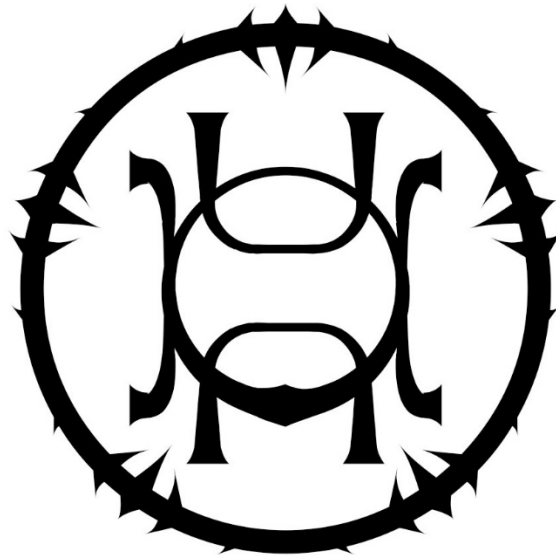
- Ott: “They kept asking me about where Xanathar kept the Eye! I don’t even know what that is!”
- Ott: “I knew Xanathar would send someone to rescue me! ... You’re not with Xanathar? Well, thank you for saving me! We could use a few more good people like you right now with what those filthy Zhent bastards are doing! I could take you back to HQ and make some introductions if you’d like to sign up!”
- Or maybe the PCs can convince him they *are* Xanatharian agents and have him lead them back to Xanathar’s lair. Ott managed to resist torture for a long time, but in his immense gratitude he makes some errors in judgment.

YELLOWSPIRE (Castle Ward): Use the Winter version of the Old Tower (see *Dragon Heist*, p. 79). It is occupied by Amath Seccent (LE female Mulan **priest**), a Banite priestess allied with Manshoon, and her four **acolytes**.

- Seccent is friends with Agorn Fuoco (see *Part 3C: Response Teams*), and he may also be found visiting here.
- *GM Note:* The permanent teleportation circle in Yellowspire is one method of accessing Manshoon's lair.
- *GM Note:* If the Gralhunds are still active in the Grand Game, one of their agents, Chirada, may be keeping Yellowspire under observation from a small apartment across the street. (See "A Missive from Castle Ward" in Area G12 of the Gralhund Villa.) Alternatively, following Chirada's advice, the Gralhunds may be mounting an expedition to raid Yellowspire, access the teleportal, and try to find the Second Eye.

Area O2 – Ground Level: A crumpled note has been carelessly tossed to one side.

- **Crumpled Note:** "Seccent—I have nothing but contempt for what you have done. I don't know what foul rites you hope to perform, but the more traditional rites of Brindul Alley would have surely wrung any information this broadsheet publisher might have had. Nonetheless, Manshoon's word is my command, and so I present to you Shan Chien. May you choke on him. – Avareen"



USING THE OUTPOSTS

These Outposts are fairly flexible in their utility. The DM should be actively playing each faction, and these outposts are some of the tools they can use while doing so. (No different than playing a PC and using their equipment list.) Structurally speaking, however, they're primarily designed to be pit stops or side quests for the PCs as they head for each faction's Lair (see Part 4), allowing them to gather intelligence (including, for example, the actual location of hidden lairs and/or the means of accessing them).

Here are some ways to use the Outposts:

- If the PCs want to find a faction by doing general research, point them at the Outposts first. (The Outposts contain clues that point to the Lairs.)
- In some cases, the Outposts will also include vectors accessing Lairs that are difficult to access. (For example, the teleportation circle in Yellowspire or the gladiatorial audience caravans leaving from the Terasse Estate.)
- The PCs are invited to meet with a faction. (This is particularly true for Jarlaxle's theater, for example.)
- The villains have kidnapped a friend or ally of the PCs. They're being held in one of the Outposts and the PCs need to either rescue them or go to the Outpost and pay their ransom.
- Villainous operations targeting the PCs or other factions will be based out of the Outposts, giving the PCs an opportunity to track or backtrack them. (For example, a Xanathar raid targeting Jarlaxle's ship might be based out of Grinda Garloth's, perhaps even with the Apparatus of Kwalish coming into play.)

From the very beginning of the campaign, keep an eye out for opportunities to point the PCs at the Outposts from unusual angles. For example, maybe they go looking for a supplier of magic armor. Send them to Grinda Garloth's. Or maybe they're sent to Fenerus Stormcastle as someone who can help them unravel some guild trouble. Even if these opportunities don't immediately lead the PCs to investigate these Outposts, it opens the door for them to be [reincorporated](#) later when they crop up as part of the Grand Game.

Also refer to *Part 5: Clues and Timelines* to see the revelation lists which will result in the PCs moving between and through the Outposts.

USING THE CASSALANTER OUTPOSTS

Because the PCs may end up working for the Cassalanter, the use of their Outposts deserves some special consideration.

If the PCs *don't* agree to help the Cassalanter, the dynamics of the Cassalanter's involvement in the campaign will completely change. This is discussed in more detail in *Part 3C: Response Teams*.

On the other hand, if the PCs agree to help the Cassalanter, then the Cassalanter are generally going to want to keep them at arm's-length from the rest of their operations. (They recognize that the risk of outing themselves as devil-worshippers and losing the PCs' support is too high.) In this scenario, the PCs may be able to follow clues from some of the other factions to Cassalanter operations and figure out that something isn't right, but the odds are low.

The DM, therefore, needs to make a decision: Do they want to make it likely that the Cassalanter will get away with it and pull one over on the PCs? Or do they want the PCs to discover what kind of alliance they've made half-way through the Grand Game?

If it's the former, simply do nothing: With the PCs working for them, the Cassalanter probably don't have to do *anything* to get what they want. And they're smart enough to sit back and do exactly that.

If it's the latter, have the Harpers or a similar organization tell the PCs that they've discovered evidence of devil-worshippers active at a site in the North Ward and send the PCs to investigate the Asmodean Shrine: Once there, they have fairly good odds of discovering evidence that implicates the Cassalanter.